▼ GLASSHOUSE



A VERY LOOSE CANNON

Congress MP and CWC member **Shashi Tharoor** has once again set the cat among the pigeons in the party. The latest is his praise for BJP nonagenarian and "true statesman" L.K. Advani, whose long public career, he argued, should not be reduced to one event—the 1990 Rath Yatra that led to the Babri Masjid demolition. The Advani affirmation follows an essay he had written the previous week describing India's dynastic political culture as a "serious threat to democracy" and, horror of horrors, saying the Nehru-Gandhi family's dominance had entrenched the idea of political leadership as birthright. The BJP gleefully hailed the "insightful" article, while the Congress almost went apoplectic. Earlier this year, the Thiruvananthapuram MP's praise for Prime Minister Narendra Modi's public schemes had provoked the party's Kerala unit into disowning him, saying he "was not one of us". That sentiment has possibly taken a life of its own now.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ DEVILS IN THE DETAIL

SHARING BLAME

There's never a dull moment when **Nitin Gadkari** takes the mike. Speaking at a recent CII meet on smart roads in Delhi, the Union minister was at his humorous best, explaining why he wants every detail about road projects displayed on signboards right on the highways. And by "every detail", he didn't just mean the contractor's name or project cost, but also the list of officials involved, from the secretary and joint secretary to other policymakers. "Why should I shoulder the blame alone for bad roads?" he quipped, drawing laughter from the audience. Behind the humour, though, lay a serious message: plans are under way to ensure such on-site transparency is the norm.

